

cover story INDO-US NUCLEAR DEAL

sustained the legacy. Manmohan didn't have it in him. He caved in so easily.

Pitted against him was the rocky perseverance of the dogmatist, the chief oxygen supplier to the UPA Government. For CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat, surrendering to imperialism was a higher risk than a mid-term election. The prospect of an election could not have rattled Manmohan. Like Karat, he had never won one. In the end, it was a combination of pressure from the allies and pleas from his own party colleagues in the Lok Sabha who were not ready for a mid-term poll that finally forced the prime minister to blink. The last blow came when Sonia did a U-turn. On October 7, at a rally in Jhajjar, Haryana, she had praised the nuclear deal and said the enemies of development were enemies of the state. Within minutes this was interpreted as a thinly-veiled attack on the Left. But the very next day, before the prime minister had had his morning cup of tea and Marie biscuits, Sonia had backed down. Late that night, her Political Adviser Ahmad Patel was burning up the wires, telling the arbiters at AKG Bhavan that Sonia's reference should only be seen in the context of Haryana. Manmohan was quick to read the writing on the wall. Five days later, he uttered the words of surrender: "If the deal does not come through, it will be disappointing. But in life, one has to take disappointments and move on. The deal is not the end of life."

Despite their public posturing, the allies have been jittery throughout. In the decisive UPA-Left meet on October 9, it was the normally silent NCP chief Sharad Pawar who said that while the allies had no objections to the deal per se, they would choose the Government over the deal if asked to choose between the two. "If there is no Government, then there is no deal," he said. He was supported by RJD's Lalu Prasad, who said no one wanted an election right now. Certainly not RJD, NCP or DMK. While Lalu is aware of Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's popularity in Bihar, both Pawar and DMK chief M. Karunanidhi fear an anti-incumbency wave in Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu, respectively. Lalu then delivered



RED RESISTANCE PRAKASH KARAT

"Even before the nuclear cooperation agreement was finalised, the UPA began to tune its foreign policy to the strategic alliance with the US."

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"Before taking another step on the deal, the Government must remember that the Congress has just 150 MPs. The Government is running on Left support."

SEPTEMBER 24, 2007

a little homily about the futility of making the nuclear deal a poll issue, suggesting to both the Congress and the Left that they focus on more popular issues. When CPI(M) Politburo member Sitaram Yechury agreed, Lalu told him, "You agree here, but when we go out, you hand us a paper listing objections."

Karunanidhi's turnaround, though, has baffled his own allies. "Not once did he raise any objections to the deal. Now, he is suddenly claiming that he had always opposed it," says a senior Union minister. Soon after the prime minister challenged the comrades, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee flew down to Chennai to meet the Tamil Nadu chief minister. Reportedly, Karunanidhi did not object to the deal even then. Friend and former prime

minister V.P. Singh persuaded him to change his mind.

The Congress also got a lesson in coalition politics from Yechury, who pointed out that BJP had shelved contentious issues like Article 370, uniform civil code and the Ram mandir for the sake of its allies. But the Congress's core group, which met at the prime minister's residence on October 8, was divided on the issue of confrontation. Interestingly, it was the three men appointed by Sonia to win the allies over who seemed the most sceptical. The trio of Patel, Mukherjee and Defence Minister A.K. Antony advised against making the nuclear deal the reason for mid-term polls.

The mood in South Block is far from euphoric. The Congress is desperately